Virginia Tech
Department of Economics
Summer 2026

ECON 3204: Intermediate Macroeconomics[1]

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Class Time: Monday to Friday
11:00 a.m. – 12:15 p.m.

Instructor Office Hour Times: By appointment
3055, Pamplin Hall (3rd floor) or Zoom

Course Description and Objectives

This intermediate macroeconomics course builds on introductory concepts, providing a deeper understanding of the principles shaping national economies. The course covers macroeconomic models, delves into schools of thought, and requires mathematical proficiency, preparing students for higher-level studies and practical applications. Students will explore advanced analytical frameworks through discussions and practical applications, enhancing their ability to analyze macroeconomic trends and policies critically. By the end of the course, students are expected to have a stronger grasp of the fundamental concepts and develop essential analytical skills for assessing economic situations.

Students often find the course to be rigorous and demanding. **We will move quickly and cover a large amount of material**. I advise you to prepare for class and keep up with the material, as the course does not lend itself to memorization or all-night cram sessions.

Prerequisites

ECON and MATH pre-req: (ECON 2006 or ECON 2026H) and (ECON 3104 or ECON 2025H) and (MATH 1226 or MATH 1526 or MATH 1026). Students without prerequisites will be dropped.

[1] Important: You should carefully read all information given in this syllabus. If you want to email me with a question, you should check the syllabus to see if your question is answered here before asking me. As a course policy, I direct students to the syllabus for questions already covered in that document.

If you switched math sequences or have transfer credit, consult Erica Perdue in Pamplin 3030 (eperdue@vt.edu) to make sure that you have the necessary preparation for this course. Students without the necessary prerequisites will be dropped from the course.

Course Materials

1. "Macroeconomics". Blanchard, O.
2. "Advanced Macroeconomics". Romer, D.

Requirements (and grading weight)

A. Homework Questionnaires, like Problem Sets (15%)

Homework Questionnaires will involve solving problems and answering questions related to the material we covered in class. All the questions will require a handwritten answer.

You may use the textbook, personal notes, or other reference material to do the homework. You are encouraged to work with your classmates. However, everyone must turn in their own work and write the answers in their own words. If homework is identical to a classmate's, you may not receive credit for the answer. Please note that all violations will be reported to the Academic Integrity Office in accordance with university policy.

Assignments and due dates will be posted in Canvas. Homework Questionnaires are due by 11:59 p.m. on the specified date. You can submit a physical copy to me or upload it to Canvas. 15 points will be taken off for each day past the due date that the homework is turned in. Once the homework solutions are posted, you cannot receive above a 35%.

In total, there are 5 Homework Questionnaires. I will keep your 4 best-scoring homework assignments, so only 4 will contribute to your final grade.

Homework questionnaires will be graded based on completion. This means that your grade will depend on how thoroughly you complete the assignment. In addition to accuracy, I will also assess how you approach the questions and how you explain your reasoning. *E.g.*, if there are ten questions and you did not answer one, and one answer has nothing to do with the question, you would get 80%, even if the remaining eight answers are not perfect.

B. Midterms (25% each, i.e., total 75%)

There will be three in-class, closed-book midterm exams throughout the semester, at the regularly scheduled class time. The first midterm will be on Friday, July 17, the second on Wednesday, August 5, and the third on Friday, August 14. There are no makeups for midterms unless you have a documented emergency (e.g., serious injury, death of a family member).

C. Exit tickets, aka assistance (10%)

You will complete an "exit ticket" at the end of each class. This will take the form of a Google Form with two or three short questions related to that day's lesson.

Each day, I will randomly select (by spinning a wheel) whether the exit ticket is required. Therefore, there is no fixed number of exit tickets you will need to complete.

Like homework questionnaires, exit tickets will be graded based on completion.

Please keep in mind that all class sessions will be recorded. As a result, if the number of exit tickets received does not correspond to the number of students who attended class, I will be able to identify students who submitted an exit ticket despite being absent.

The Exit Ticket must be completed within approximately 5–6 minutes after it is posted on Canvas during class, *as it is intended to reflect attendance and participation* in that day's lesson. Therefore, submissions made after that time window cannot be accepted.

In summary, final grades for the course will be based on the following:

Homework questionnaires	15%
Midterm 1	25%
Midterm 2	25%
Midterm 3	25%
Assistance	10%

Letter grades will be assigned as follows:

A	96-100	C+	76-77.99
A-	90-95.99	C	73-76.99
B+	85-89.99	C-	70-72.99
B	81-84.99	D	60-69.99
B-	78-80.99	F	0-59.99

Grading Questions or Disputes

I want you to understand how you are evaluated in this class. If you have any questions about your grade or feedback on coursework, please email me to schedule a time to meet. I kindly ask that you wait at least 24 hours after work has been returned before requesting an appointment. This is to give you time to consider your questions about your work more thoroughly.

I will calculate the final course grade using grades with one or two decimal places; the final course grade will not be rounded to the nearest integer. For example, 69.4% will not be rounded to 70, 69.5% will not be rounded to 70, and 69.9% will not be rounded to 70.

Attendance
Attendance is not mandatory, but as mentioned in the **Requirements** part, the Exit Tickets component fundamentally relies on attendance: 10%.

Canvas
Our website within Canvas (https://canvas.vt.edu/) will have the slides, class assignments, information, and more. Please check the website regularly for class updates.

Instructor Office Hours and Attention via Email
I strongly recommend contacting me via email with questions related to the course material. Visiting my office for personalized assistance with your questions and doubts is also an option.

I typically respond to emails twice a week:

I respond to those emails that were sent on:	On:
Saturday, Sunday, and Monday	Tuesday
Tuesday, Wednesday, and Thursday	Friday

Any questions emailed to me concerning course material will be answered via email and could be shared with all students in the class anonymously.

COVID, Flu, and Sickness Policy
In the case of COVID or other contagious diseases, we will follow the current guidance from the Virginia Department of Health. The Virginia Department of Health recommends staying home when exhibiting signs of respiratory illness and returning to school when symptoms have improved for at least 24 hours and there is no sign of fever. Additionally, it is recommended that upon returning to school or work, you take precautions for five days to prevent the spread of illness to others.

If you do get sick, please let me know. I will make reasonable accommodations to make up any material. This policy may be updated as recommendations change.

Use of Generative AI
While the use of AI tools, including ChatGPT, Grok, CoPilot, Claude, DeepSeek, Gemini, and other AI-powered writing or research assistive technologies, may be tempting, it is important to consider the ethical implications of their use.

In this course, students are encouraged to consult with the instructor before using any such tools. If approved, the use of AI tools must be properly cited and acknowledged in all submissions. Failure to follow these guidelines may result in a grade penalty or other disciplinary action as determined by the instructor.

If an answer appears to have been generated by AI, I will use up to four different AI tools to assess it. Each tool will provide a probability score indicating how likely it is that the answer was AI-generated. If the average of these scores is above 85%, the answer will be invalid and will not receive credit.

Academic Honesty
One of the goals of this course is to prepare you to do well in advanced economics courses, so you must develop a solid understanding of the material. To that end, while collaboration on problem sets is encouraged in this course, copying is not. Students are expected to understand and abide by the University's honor code (https://honorsystem.vt.edu/).

Withdrawal
Sometimes students may need to withdraw from a class because of personal or academic reasons. If your performance in the class is not where you want it to be or if you are experiencing difficulties, please don't hesitate to contact me before withdrawing.
Ask your academic advisor what the last day is to drop individual courses.

Undergraduate Academic Integrity Statement
The Undergraduate Honor Code pledge that each member of the university community agrees to abide by states:

"As a Hokie, I will conduct myself with honor and integrity at all times. I will not lie, cheat, or steal, nor will I accept the actions of those who do."

Students enrolled in this course are responsible for abiding by the undergraduate Honor Code on each assignment and/or exam. A student who has doubts about how the Honor Code applies to any assignment is responsible for obtaining specific guidance from the course instructor before submitting the assignment for evaluation. Students are strongly discouraged from misusing unauthorized online sources, including generative artificial intelligence outlets. Students are strongly encouraged to consult their faculty members regarding the use of such outside materials, as the misuse of these sources may constitute a violation of the Honor Code. Ignorance of the rules does not exclude any member of the University community from the requirements and expectations of the Honor Code

Academic Accommodations

Virginia Tech welcomes students with disabilities into the University's educational programs. The University promotes efforts to provide equal access and a culture of inclusion without altering the essential elements of coursework. If you anticipate or experience academic barriers that may be due to disability, including but not limited to ADHD, chronic or temporary medical conditions, deaf or hard of hearing, learning disability, mental health, or vision impairment, please contact the Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD) office (540-231-3788, ssd@vt.edu, or visit ssd.vt.edu). If you have an SSD accommodation letter, please meet with me privately during office hours as early in the semester as possible to deliver your letter and discuss your accommodations. You must give me reasonable notice to implement your accommodations, which is generally 5 business days and 10 business days for final exams.

If there are aspects of this course that prevent you from learning or exclude you, please let me know as soon as possible. Together, we'll develop strategies to meet both your needs and the requirements of the course.

Basic Needs Statement
For any student who has difficulty affording groceries, accessing sufficient food to eat every day, or who lacks a safe and stable place to live, and if you believe this may affect your performance in this course, you are urged to contact the Dean of Students office for support at 540-231-3787 or complete an interest form to participate in The Market at Virginia Tech.

The Dean of Students, through The Market at Virginia Tech, offers food options and other resources. There is also a Student Emergency Fund program. If you are comfortable in doing so, please notify your departmental advisor or me of your situation. This will enable them to provide any resources they have access to.

Lauren's Promise: I will listen and believe you if someone is threatening or harassing you.

Lauren McCluskey, a 21-year-old student at the University of Utah and the daughter of economist Jill McCluskey, was murdered on October 22nd, 2018, by a man she had briefly dated. I am committed to doing what I can to make sure this does not happen again.

If you are in immediate danger, call 911. If you are experiencing sexual assault, domestic violence, stalking, or harassment, you can report it to me. You should be aware that I am a mandatory reporter, which means that I am required to report these instances to the university's Title IX Coordinator or Deputy Title IX Coordinator to investigate. **You can also learn about your options (both on and off-campus, as well as confidential or not) at https://oea.vt.edu/title-ix-vawa.html**. If you need support for your mental or emotional health for any reason, you can talk to me. You can also find helpful resources at **https://ucc.vt.edu/**.

Weather Policy

If the University is officially closed on an exam or assignment due date, the exam or the due date of the assignment will be moved to the next scheduled class date.

Mental Health Wellness

Ensuring the well-being of our students, both academically and mentally, is a top priority at Virginia Tech and for me. If you find yourself feeling overwhelmed by academic demands, grappling with mental health challenges, or concerned about the welfare of a friend, please know that there are resources available to support you:

- Cook Counseling: Call 540-231-6557 to schedule an appointment and/or 24/7 crisis support or go online at ucc.vt.edu for more info.
- Dean of Students Office: Call 540-231-3787 for general advice. Call 540-231-6411 for after-hours crisis or go online at dos.vt.edu for more info.
- Hokie Wellness: Go online to hokiewellness.vt.edu for more info about health and wellness workshops and consultations.

You can find a full listing of campus resources at Well-being at Virginia Tech.